

Revamped Green India Mission: A matter of vulnerable ecosystems and livelihoods

The government's **decision** to revise the Green India Mission (GIM) and focus on **restoring** vulnerable **landscapes**, such as those in the Aravalli range, the Western Ghats and the Himalaya, **is** welcome. Framed in 2014 during the last days of the UPA government, the mission is not only **crucial** to **meeting** India's climate **commitments**, it is also important for biodiversity conservation and food and water security. The initiative has **resulted in** an **appreciable** increase in the country's tree cover. However, it has been **criticised** for taking a plantation-centred approach and not doing justice to the mission's broader goal of **ecological revival**. The GIM's revised **document attempts** to **course correct**. Especially **salient** is its **emphasis** on **zeroing in** on micro-climatic zones through "regionally **conductive** best practices". This initiative should be combined with **addressing** another concern of the original GIM, which has largely remained on paper — creating income-generating opportunities for people who rely on these ecosystems.

The Western Ghats, the Aravalli range and the Himalayan region face various challenges including **deforestation**, human-wildlife conflicts and changing rainfall patterns. Infrastructure development and unregulated tourism have added to their **vulnerabilities**. Last year, the **catastrophic** landslide in Wayanad **underlined** that the **depletion** of green cover and **erratic rainfall had** made the area **susceptible** to disasters. The new GIM document also notes that the Western Ghats ecosystem has **degraded** due to the felling of trees and illegal mining. Similarly, several studies have shown that the **destruction** of large **chunks** of the Aravalli ecosystem — especially its hills — **has** brought the Thar **Desert** close to the National Capital Region and this **desertification** has **aggravated** the area's pollution problem.

The **restoration** of most ecological **hotspots** in the country **has** been trapped in the environment-development **binary**. In 2011, a **panel** chaired by ecologist Madhav Gadgil **underlined** the need to regulate developmental activities in the entire 1,60,000 sq km **stretch** of the Western Ghats. Its recommendations were met with **resistance** across the political **spectrum**. The **suggestions** of the K Kasturirangan panel **have** also remained on paper. Similarly, illegal **quarrying** has **persisted** in the Aravalli range despite several SC orders, including as late as May 29. The problem is also that green initiatives have rarely taken people along. The **challenge** for the **revamped** GIM **will**, therefore, be to find ways to **sustain** and improve people's livelihoods while **enhancing** ecological security. **[Practice E.]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

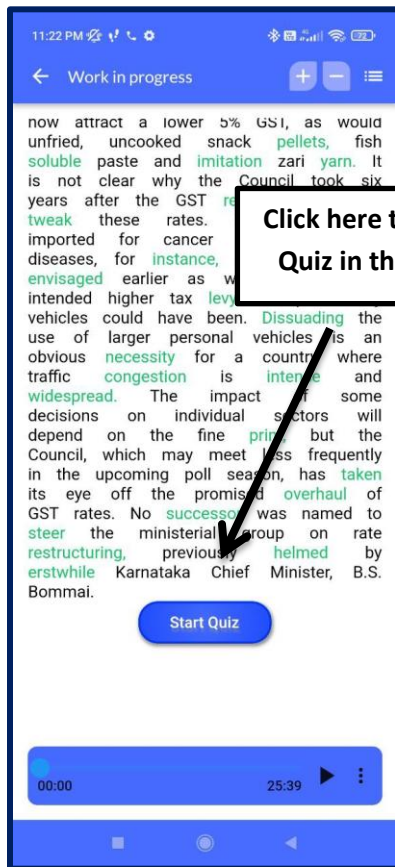
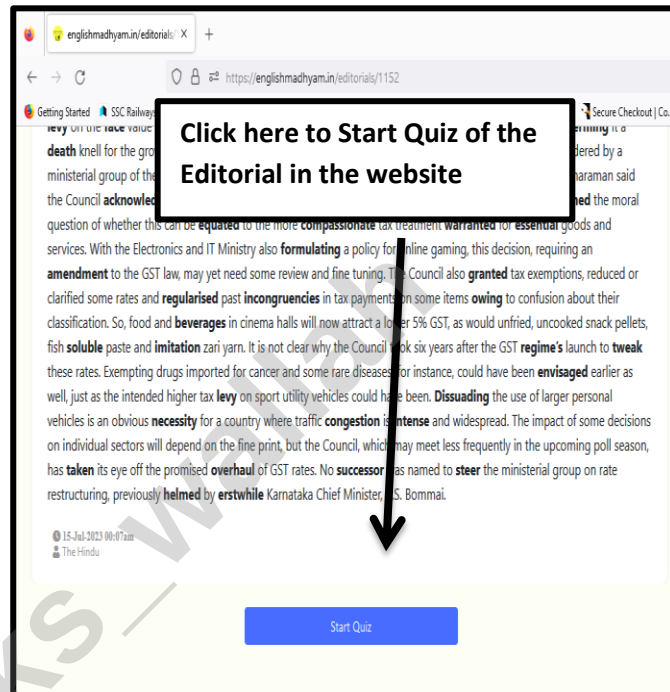
1. **Vulnerable** (adjective) – exposed, unprotected, defenseless, weak, susceptible असुरक्षित
2. **Ecosystem** (noun) – environment, ecological system, biosphere, habitat, biotic community पारिस्थितिकी तंत्र
3. **Livelihood** (noun) – income, employment, occupation, sustenance, means of living आजीविका
4. **Restore** (verb) – revive, regenerate, reinstate, repair, rehabilitate पुनर्स्थापित करना
5. **Landscape** (noun) – terrain, scenery, environment, topography, geography परिदृश्य
6. **Crucial** (adjective) – essential, vital, critical, key, significant महत्वपूर्ण
7. **Meet** (verb) – fulfill, satisfy, comply with, achieve, attain पूरा करना
8. **Commitment** (noun) – promise, obligation, pledge, responsibility, assurance प्रतिबद्धता
9. **Result in** (phrasal verb) – lead to, cause, bring about, produce, generate परिणामस्वरूप होना
10. **Appreciable** (adjective) – noticeable, significant, considerable, substantial, perceptible प्रशंसनीय / उल्लेखनीय
11. **Criticise** (verb) – condemn, blame, fault, disapprove, censure आलोचना करना
12. **Ecological** (adjective) – environmental, green, natural, eco-friendly पारिस्थितिक
13. **Revival** (noun) – renewal, regeneration, comeback, reawakening, resurgence पुनरुत्थान
14. **Course correct** (phrase) – adjust, rectify, reform, realign, amend मार्ग सुधारना
15. **Salient** (noun) – highlight, main point, prominent feature, key aspect प्रमुख बिंदु
16. **Emphasis** (noun) – stress, importance, attention, focus, priority ज़ोर
17. **Zero in** (phrasal verb) – focus on, target, concentrate, direct attention, home in ध्यान केंद्रित करना
18. **Conducive** (adjective) – favorable, beneficial, helpful, suitable, supportive अनुकूल
19. **Address** (verb) – deal with, tackle, handle, respond to, resolve हल करना
20. **Deforestation** (noun) – tree-cutting, forest clearance, clearing, logging, forest destruction वनों की कटाई
21. **Vulnerability** (noun) – weakness, exposure, risk, sensitivity, openness कमजोरी / जोखिम

22. **Catastrophic** (adjective) – disastrous, devastating, calamitous, ruinous, tragic
विनाशकारी
23. **Underline** (verb) – emphasize, highlight, stress, point out, reinforce ज़ोर देना
24. **Depletion** (noun) – reduction, exhaustion, decline, consumption, loss क्षय / कमी
25. **Erratic** (adjective) – unpredictable, inconsistent, irregular, unstable, changeable अनियमित
26. **Susceptible** (to) (adjective) – prone, vulnerable, open, sensitive, inclined संवेदनशील
27. **Degrade** (verb) – deteriorate, weaken, damage, erode, ruin बिगड़ना / गिरावट आना
28. **Chunk** (noun) – portion, segment, part, slab, mass टुकड़ा
29. **Desert** (noun) – arid land, wasteland, sand plain, barren region रेगिस्तान
30. **Desertification** (noun) – land degradation, aridification, desiccation, ecological deterioration मरुस्थलीकरण
31. **Aggravate** (verb) – worsen, intensify, exacerbate, heighten, compound और खराब करना
32. **Restoration** (noun) – renewal, rebuilding, revival, repair, regeneration पुनर्स्थापन
33. **Hotspot** (noun) – sensitive area, danger zone, critical region, conflict zone संवेदनशील क्षेत्र
34. **Binary** (noun) – opposition, contrast, dichotomy, division, dualism द्वैत / द्वंद्व
35. **Stretch** (noun) – expanse, area, length, span, tract फैलाव
36. **Resistance** (noun) – opposition, defiance, protest, refusal, noncompliance विरोध
37. **Spectrum** (noun) – range, span, scope, scale, extent विविधता / श्रृंखला
38. **Quarrying** (noun) – mining, excavation, extraction, digging, stone removal खनन
39. **Persist** (verb) – continue, endure, remain, carry on, prevail बना रहना
40. **Revamped** (adjective) – updated, revised, renewed, restructured, modernized संशोधित
41. **Sustain** (verb) – support, maintain, uphold, nourish, continue बनाए रखना
42. **Enhance** (verb) – improve, boost, augment, raise, strengthen सुधारना

Summary of the Editorial

1. The government has revised the Green India Mission (GIM) to focus on restoring vulnerable ecosystems like the Aravalli range, Western Ghats, and the Himalayas.
2. Originally launched in 2014 during the UPA government, GIM is vital for climate commitments, biodiversity, and food and water security.
3. The mission has increased tree cover, but has faced criticism for being too plantation-centric, lacking broader ecological restoration.
4. The revised GIM aims to course-correct by focusing on micro-climatic zones and promoting regionally suited best practices.
5. A long-ignored goal of the mission — creating livelihood opportunities for local communities — must now be seriously implemented.
6. The Western Ghats, Aravallis, and Himalayas face multiple threats: deforestation, human-wildlife conflict, and unpredictable rainfall.
7. Unregulated infrastructure and tourism have further intensified these regions' vulnerability to ecological degradation.
8. The 2023 Wayanad landslide highlighted how loss of green cover and erratic rain can lead to climate disasters.
9. The Western Ghats have suffered from tree felling and illegal mining, severely damaging the ecosystem.
10. The Aravalli hills' destruction has led to desertification, bringing the Thar Desert closer to NCR and worsening air pollution.
11. Restoration efforts often get stuck in the development vs. environment debate, hindering decisive action.
12. The Madhav Gadgil panel (2011) had recommended strict regulation across the Western Ghats, but its advice faced widespread resistance.
13. The K. Kasturirangan panel's recommendations have also largely remained unimplemented.
14. Despite repeated Supreme Court orders, including one in May 2024, illegal quarrying in the Aravallis continues unchecked.
15. For the revamped GIM to succeed, it must balance ecology with livelihoods, ensuring that local communities are active participants in conservation.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based

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